

1.2 Need for Religion

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

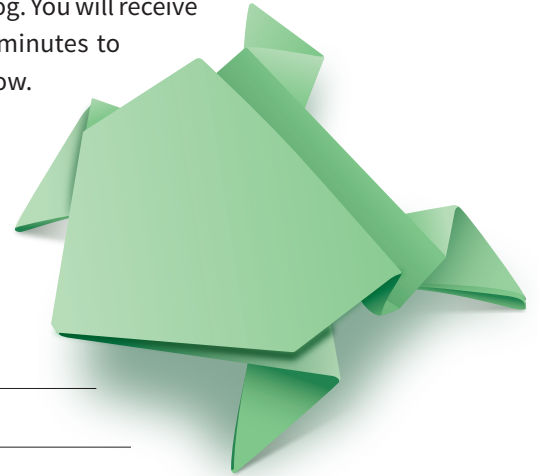
- Recognize that religion fulfills all of the needs of a human being.
- Learn about the origins and purpose of religion.
- Learn why every person needs to investigate for themselves in order to find a way of life.
- Learn the connection between our purpose and religion.
- Learn about the two guides: intellect (*'aql*) and innate nature (*fiṭrah*), and examine their roles in guiding us toward closeness with Allah ﷻ.
- Focus on how our internal and external guides help us find Allah ﷻ.
- Learn how our innate nature (*fiṭrah*) can become hidden or covered up.

'AQL: Intellect

FIṬRAH: Our innate God-seeking nature

Activity 1.2a: Pre-Reading Craft

Your job is to create an origami jumping frog. You will receive a piece of origami paper. You have five minutes to create the same frog that is pictured below. Then, answer the questions below:



1. Were you successful at creating the frog?

2. How easy or difficult was it to create the frog?

3. What would have made it easier for you to create the frog?

4. How do you think this activity relates to our need for religion?



STORY RECAP: Ibrahim is a young boy who woke up in a garden, locked in by glass walls. He was given a message that told him to search for his purpose in life.

IBRAHIM'S DREAM Part 2: The Glass Walls

Ibrahim's head was throbbing after hitting the glass wall so many times. He pressed his face against the glass wall, looking longingly at the stream behind it. It was so close, yet so unattainable. He knew that he had to get there, but he was not sure how. *There has to be a way out*, he thought to himself, but he was too overwhelmed with all of the different things around him, and how little he understood them. He had tried several ways to get to the other side, but none of them worked.

He tried standing on a rock and climbing up a tree trying to throw himself over, but the glass walls were way too high. He tried walking around them, but the glass walls seemed to go on endlessly. Exasperated, he started to throw rocks at them, hoping that they would somehow shatter. But it seemed as if they were bulletproof because they did not shatter at all. Nothing seemed to work. *There has to be a way!* Ibrahim thought to himself. *It would be so much easier if I had clear instructions or someone to just show me the way!* He thought about the bookshelf that he had just built with his father the week before, and how they used instructions to help them along the way. He wished that this glass wall area had instructions too.

Looking through the glass wall, Ibrahim was shocked! He noticed an old man in the distance near the stream, holding a huge bottle of water. This man had gotten the water that Ibrahim needed desperately, so it was possible to get to the stream! If only the old man could show him the way, Ibrahim could be successful as well. *Maybe the old man has been sent to help me*, Ibrahim thought to himself.

"Hey!" Ibrahim screamed, waving his arms, desperately trying to get the old man's attention. "I need your help to get some water!" The man did not look up at Ibrahim, despite the commotion that he was making. Ibrahim started to bang on the glass and continued to yell. The man was either hard of hearing, or the glass walls were soundproof, so the man simply could not hear him!

Ibrahim was growing desperate; he did not know which direction to go, so he started to run frantically along the glass wall, not really paying attention to where he was going. When he stopped to catch his breath, he saw a shiny wrapper partially buried in the ground. He started to dig for it, thinking that it may contain some food or water. After digging for a while, he saw that it was empty, and when he looked up he realized that he had completely lost sight of the old man. The stream now seemed to be even further away!

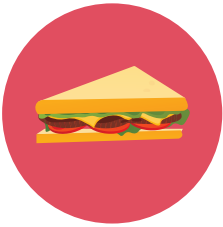
Ibrahim sighed and sat down on a rock, wiping away the beads of sweat that had formed on his forehead. He stared hopelessly at the grass in front of him. The grass looked so odd—parts of it were burned, and other parts were lush and green. *What is this place?* he thought. He looked again and suddenly realized that a message had been burned into the grass. It said: "Wear the glasses." He had been so involved with the wrapper that he had missed the message! The message confused him even more, but he wanted to get out of the glass enclosure. How would glasses help him? He did not really understand, but at least now he knew what to look for: glasses.



Activity 1.2b: Quick Write & Reflection



QUICK WRITE: In 60 seconds, make a list of games, activities, or events that would not be possible to engage in without a proper and/or thorough set of instructions.



REFLECTION: How does the same apply for things we do in our lives? What if we had no set rules or guidelines for them?

WHAT IS RELIGION?

All religions are composed of two main parts: beliefs and practices. In order to be a true follower of any religion, we must understand why we follow the religion that we do, and also follow certain guidelines that are laid out.



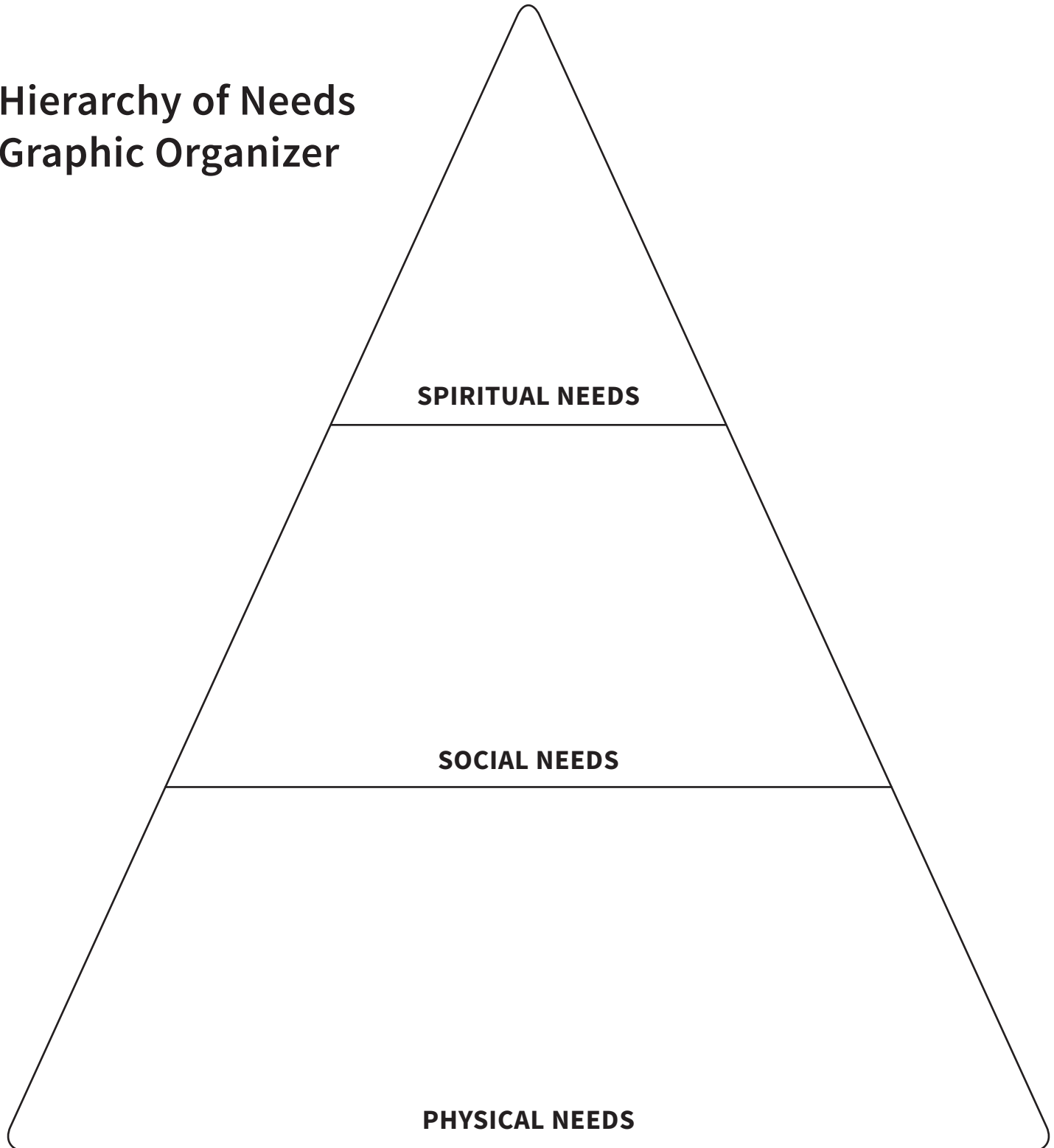
STOP AND REFLECT: What is the difference between beliefs and practices?

As humans, we have three types of needs: physical needs, social/emotional needs, and other higher/spiritual needs. Physical needs are those needs that are necessary for our survival, like food, water, and shelter. Social/emotional needs include our need to communicate with family and friends, the need to be cared for, and things that are essential for a society to function, like laws, leaders, and governments. Finally, higher or spiritual needs are those that our soul needs to thrive, like knowing our purpose in life, and having a meaningful way to live our lives. These spiritual needs are part of our consciousness and essence as human beings, and are what set us apart from animals.

Activity 1.2c: Fulfilling our Hierarchy of Needs

There is an abundance of guidance within the Qurʾān and *ḥadīth* to help us best fulfill our various needs. Read through the selection of *āyāt* or *ḥadīth* listed on the following pages, and copy them into the graphic organizer under the coinciding tiers of human needs that each excerpt addresses; alternatively, you may place the excerpt number in the corresponding tier.

Hierarchy of Needs Graphic Organizer



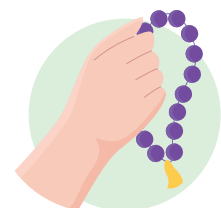
Activity 1.2c: Fulfilling our Hierarchy of Needs (Continued)

The following Qur'ānic verses, and *ḥadīth* relate to the three types of human needs: physical needs, social/emotional needs, and other higher/spiritual needs. Using the numbering system, place the excerpts into the related tier of the **Hierarchy of Needs Graphic Organizer** on the previous page:

From the Qur'ān:

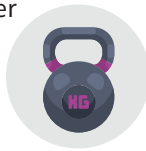
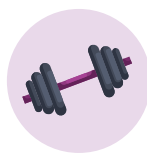
1. Allah ﷻ recommended us to: “Eat what is lawful and good on the Earth.”¹
2. Some foods which are beneficial for our health: honey,² vegetables such as corn, herbs, and grains,^{3&4} and fruits such as olives, dates, grapes, pomegranates,⁵ and bananas.⁶
3. Allah ﷻ also recommends us to eat the meat of certain animals and their milk, as well as fresh fish and birds: “And He created cattle for you, wherein is warmth and (many) gains, and you eat thereof;”⁷ and: “He has provided for them the beast of the camel. So eat them and feed the miserable and the poor.”⁸
4. References advocating physical activity can be inferred from the Qur'ānic verses and Prophetic traditions, which share the common theme of maintaining respect for the body: “Do not with your own hands throw yourself into ruin.”⁹
5. “Prosperous is the one who purifies the soul, and failed is the one who soils it with sins (and impurity).”¹⁰
6. “But Allah has endeared to you faith, and has made it pleasing in your hearts; and He has made detestable to you disbelief, ungodliness, and disobedience.”¹¹
7. “And do not turn your face from people (in scorn and pride), and do not walk on the earth exultantly; indeed Allah does not love anyone proud and boastful.”¹²
8. “It is not piety (righteous) that you turn your faces to the East or to the West. (True) piety is to have faith in Allah and the Last Day, the angels, the Book, and the Prophets; and to give of one's wealth, in spite of love for it, to the relatives, the orphans, the needy, the traveller, those who ask (for help), and to free the slaves; (and those who) perform the prayers, and pay the alms. And those who fulfill their covenant when they have engaged in a covenant; and endure with fortitude (during) misfortune, hardship, and dangers. They are the ones who are true in their faith; and they are the God-fearing (and righteous ones).”¹³

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- 1 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Baqarah (2), Verse 168.
 - 2 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah an-Nahl (16), Verses 68-69.
 - 3 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah ar-Raḥmān (55), Verse 12.
 - 4 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah 'Abasa (80), Verse 27.
 - 5 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-An'ām (6), Verses 99 and 141.
 - 6 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Wāqī'ah (56), Verse 29.
 - 7 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah an-Nahl (16), Verse 5.
 - 8 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Hajj (22), Verse 28.
 - 9 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Baqarah (2), Verse 195.
 - 10 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah ash-Shams (91), Verses 9-10.
 - 11 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Hujurat (49), Verse 7.
 - 12 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah Luqman (31), Verse 18.
 - 13 Noble Qur'ān, Sūrah al-Baqarah (2), Verse 177.



Examples from Ḥadīth:

9. In the following ḥadīth, the Prophet ﷺ advises against overeating: “Do not indulge in overeating because it will quench the light of faith within your hearts.”¹⁴
10. Another frequently cited ḥadīth recommends that a person should fill one-third of the stomach with food, one-third with water, and one-third should be left empty.
11. It has been narrated that the Prophet ﷺ and Imām ‘Alī ؑ would refrain from eating bread made from refined flour, rather they ate that which contained barley and bran.¹⁵
12. Imām ‘Alī ؑ has been reported as saying: “Do not let your stomach become a graveyard for animals.”¹⁶
13. “Your body has a right over you;” and “A strong believer is better than a weak believer.”¹⁷
14. Imām ‘Alī ؑ, in his historic directive addressed to Mālik al-Ashtar, told him: “(O Mālik) The good and the wicked must not be equal in your eyes, otherwise it will discourage the good from doing good, and encourage the wicked in their misconduct. Treat them in accordance with the kind of conduct that they have chosen for themselves.”¹⁸
15. Imām ‘Alī ؑ, Commander of the Faithful, draws our attention to a (certain) point with an interesting metaphor. He says: “Be like the honeybee, which always drinks the purest of things (i.e. the nectar) and yields the purest of things, and does not break any bough that it descends on.”¹⁹
16. Imām ‘Alī ؑ said: “A person who does not appreciate the good, unmingled, and sincere intentions of one’s friend will also not appreciate their services and acts of kindness.”²⁰
17. Imām Ḥasan al-‘Askarī ؑ said: “The best of your friends are those who forget your inadequacies, but never forget your kindness.”²¹



18. Imām ‘Alī ؑ refers to this kind of loss and deprivation in the following saying: “A person who does not give thanks for a favor (done to them) will not find anything except deprivation and disappointment.”²²
19. In the directive to Mālik al-Ashtar, Imām ‘Alī ؑ points out the significance and benefits of appreciation: “(O Mālik) Attention to major matters should not make you neglect minor and less important ones, for people benefit from your trivial services and acts of kindness in their own right, although they cannot do without your major services... Pay thorough attention to the demands and needs of the people. Compensate those who take pains and do worthy work. For the tribute paid to them for their work will give enthusiasm to the brave and serve as a constant source of their motivation. This practice will also help motivate conservative and timid people and draw them to the field of battle.”²³
20. Imām ‘Alī ؑ said: “In the beginning, obtain self-control through abstaining from sins and vices. Then it will be easier for you to habituate yourself in the obedience and service of Allah.”²⁴
21. Imām ‘Alī ؑ said: “Acquire control over yourself by abandoning (bad) habits and fighting your desires, so that they become subject to the power of your will.”²⁵

14 Nayshābūrī, Ḥākim, *Al-Mustadrak ‘alā aṣ-Ṣaḥīḥayn*, Vol. 3, P. 81.

15 Iran English Radio. IRIB World Service [Internet]. Iran: Islamic Republic of Iran Broadcasting Service; c2011. Analysis; Articles; *Islam Nutrition and Health* Part 10; Feb-Jun, 2011.

16 *Path of Light / Voie de la Lumière* [Internet]. Canada: Canadian Islamic Centre of Montreal; c2007. *Islam and the Vegetarian Diet* by Cyril Anderson.

17 Al Khayat MH. The Right Path to Health: Health Education through Religion; 9. *Health as a Human Right in Islam*. World Health Organisation Regional Office for the Eastern Mediterranean, 2004, Pp. 11, 18, 21 [originally in *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim*].

18 Nietzsche, Friedrich, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (Penguin Books, 1975), P. 206.

19 Āmidī, *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 569.

20 *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 672.

21 *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 702.

22 *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 672.

23 ‘Allāmah Majlisī, *Biḥār al-Anwār*, Vol.2, P. 87.

24 *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 508.

25 *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*, P. 508.

ORIGIN OF RELIGION



Muslims believe that religion—and the worldview that comes with it—began with the very first human being: Prophet Ādam ﷺ. Throughout history, every Messenger sent by Allah ﷻ has explained the religion and worldview that human beings should have. It has been the same core message from the beginning of time, consisting of three main principles:

1. Belief in the One and Only God who created everything, and sustains everything in existence.
2. Belief in the Prophets and the message that they brought to us as a way of life.
3. Belief in the Hereafter as being our ultimate destination.



WHY SHOULD A PERSON INVESTIGATE RELIGION?

Some people may ask: “Why investigate religion at all?”



STORY CONNECTION: We see in the story of Ibrahim that he is constantly trying to look for answers because he is trapped and needs water. For him, the need to find a way to the water was very pressing. If he decided to ignore this need, or prioritize other things above it, then he may face fatal consequences. On the other hand, the pleasure that he would experience if he could get water is enough to make him continue to look for answers. Similarly, we are always searching for answers as human beings.



There are some simple reasons why all humans should look into religion. All creatures want to save themselves from even the possibility that they will be harmed. Imagine a very young child comes knocking on your door and tells you that there is a fire down the street, and if you do not leave your house and try to help the situation, then it will burn the entire neighborhood! How would you react?



STOP AND REFLECT: If this happened to you, would you go and investigate the fire, even if you do not know the child?

Now, imagine that someone you know comes to your door to warn you about a fire. Imagine that this person is very trustworthy and truthful. Everything else you know about them is good. You would likely be even more inclined to believe them.

Just like a fire in the neighborhood, we have been sent warnings about the Hereafter. Allah ﷻ sent us pious and trustworthy Prophets to warn us about the consequences of our actions, so at the very least, we need to look into their teachings and warnings. Although many people get distracted in this life and forget to look into the more important issues such as religion and faith, there are actually many benefits to believing in religion.

